

Windows Device Encryption can automatically enable BitLocker on supported systems, while BitLocker protects entire drives.

Fourth, the device must be capable of being located, locked or erased after loss.

The 20-minute Android privacy audit

Android menus differ across Pixel, Samsung, Motorola, Xiaomi and other devices, so use Settings search when a path is not identical. Consider whether each application needs information continuously, only while being used or never.

Step 1: Strengthen the lock screen

Go to Settings > Security and privacy > Device lock, or search for “screen lock”. Replace swipe, no lock, a four-digit PIN or an easily observed pattern. Choose a long PIN or password that is not a birthday, vehicle number, postcode or repeated sequence. Add fingerprint or face unlock only after establishing the stronger fallback credential.

Set the screen to lock quickly and disable trusted-place unlocking unless the convenience outweighs the risk. Hide sensitive notification content so OTPs, messages, calendar entries and delivery details do not appear to anyone holding the phone.

Step 2: Inspect permission use, not merely permission lists

Open Settings > Security and privacy > Privacy > Privacy dashboard. The dashboard shows which applications accessed permissions and when. Begin with location, microphone and camera, then inspect contacts, call logs, SMS, photographs, nearby devices and health information. Android’s Permission Manager lets you review access by data type rather than opening every application individually.

For each application, ask:

1. Does its main purpose require this permission?
2. Does it need access all the time?
3. Can “Allow only while using” replace permanent access?
4. Can approximate location replace precise location?
5. Can selected photographs replace the entire library?
6. What stops working when access is denied?

Revoke permissions from applications you do not trust. Turn on the option that pauses activity or removes permissions for unused applications where available. If an application refuses to function without access unrelated to its purpose, seek an alternative rather than surrendering by habit.

Step 3: Use the emergency camera and microphone switches

Android displays an indicator when the camera or microphone is active on supported versions. Add the Camera access and Microphone access tiles to Quick Settings so both sensors can be disabled quickly during a confidential meeting or when testing

suspicious behaviour. This system-level control is broader than changing one application’s permission.

Step 4: Reduce advertising profiling

Open Settings > Google > All services > Ads > Ads privacy. Review Ad topics, App-suggested ads and Ad measurement, and turn off categories you do not want used. Depending on the Android version, you may also be able to reset or delete the advertising ID. These controls do not stop websites or logged-in services from using other identifiers.

Step 5: Remove risky and unnecessary applications

Uninstall applications you have not used in months, especially cleaners, unofficial keyboards, abandoned VPNs, wallpaper applications and APKs obtained from messages or unknown sites. Keep Google Play Protect enabled. It checks applications for harmful behaviour, scans software from outside Google Play and may warn, deactivate or remove harmful applications.

Treat requests to enable Accessibility, notification access, device administration, installation from unknown sources or restricted settings as high-risk moments. Some malicious applications seek these privileges because they can read messages, observe notifications or control parts of the interface. Android deliberately restricts certain settings for applications installed from less trusted sources.

Step 6: Check backups and account synchronisation

Open the backup settings and inspect what is being copied: application data, device settings, photographs, videos, contacts and messages. Keep what you genuinely need, protect the cloud account with strong authentication and remove obsolete device backups.

Then examine every account listed under Passwords and accounts or Accounts. Remove former employers, unused email accounts and old synchronisation services. Check whether contacts, calendars, browser data and photographs are crossing between identity compartments.

Review the keyboard and clipboard as well. A keyboard sees almost everything typed outside protected fields, while clipboard history may retain copied addresses, OTPs or account numbers. Keep only keyboards you deliberately installed, inspect their privacy and voice-typing options, and clear learned words if suggestions reveal another identity. Gboard allows users to delete learned words and manage on-device personalisation settings. Avoid pinning sensitive clipboard entries, and paste secrets only when necessary.

Step 7: Create separation inside the phone

Where supported, use a work profile, separate user account or